An important but less well-known aspect of India's foreign policy is India's aid for other developing countries. The annual budget outlay for the Ministry of External Affairs for 2014–15 was US $2.3 billion (INR 14,370.39 crore), of which 64 per cent accounted for aid given to other countries under the International Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) programme.[36] For the year 2015–16, India's development aid budget stood at US $1.6 billion, most of which, around 84 per cent, was allocated to South Asian countries. The budget apportioned 63 per cent of the aid for Bhutan, while giving Afghanistan 7 per cent, Sri Lanka 5 per cent, Nepal 4 per cent, Bangladesh 3 per cent and the Maldives 2 per cent.[37] Pakistan is the only South Asian country that does not accept Indian aid.

Within the Ministry for External Affairs, responsibilities for managing relations with various countries are divided on a territorial basis between the three senior-most civil servants – the foreign secretary, secretary (East) and secretary (West). As part of a tradition started many years ago, until recently the foreign secretary dealt directly with the United Nations and the permanent members of the UN Security Council (the US, the UK, China, Russia and France) as well as India's South Asian neighbours. Secretary (West's) remit is Europe, Latin America, North America (but not the US), Africa and the Gulf while Secretary (East's) responsibility covers East Asia but not China.

This tradition has not always been strictly adhered to and over time, foreign secretaries have accumulated more subjects and regions under their direct control. Modi has presided over subtle changes in the management of the Ministry of External Affairs, allowing greater concentration of policymaking at the apex of the pyramid. For example, Foreign Secretary Jaishankar delegated the UN portfolio to Secretary DPA & ER Sujata Mehta to free the foreign secretary to focus on India's pursuit of a permanent seat on the Security Council. This marked separating India's larger political objectives from the humdrum of India's role at the UN and was interpreted